consensus over the Right to Health... I am hopeful the doctor-patient relationship will remain as it is in future too," he wrote on Twitter.

According to the agreement, the RTH, say officials, will exclude private hospitals with a capacity of fewer than 50 beds and those who have not taken any assistance or concessions from the government. It leaves under its ambit, besides government facilities, only private medical colleges, hospitals running on public-private partnership mode, and those set up on land allotted by the government on concessional rates. These are mostly the same facilities that have already opted for Gehlot's other flagship scheme—Chiranjeevi Health Insurance, which provides up to Rs 25 lakh cover for cashless treatment across government hospitals and indoor admissions in empanelled private hospitals.

GEHLOT MAY HAVE ENDED THE IMPASSE FOR NOW BUT WILL HAVE TO ENSURE THAT ALL CONTENTIOUS CLAUSES IN THE LAW ARE ADDRESSED

Pushing the new law had also put the Chiranjeevi scheme in jeopardy, with private institutions demanding a relook at the reimbursement slabs. "Combined with the Chiranjeevi scheme, the RTH is taking away the right to quality care from those willing to pay for it," Dr Vijay Kapoor, secretary of the state's Private Hospital and Nursing Home Societies, had said before the strike was called off. Their main contention was how a resident doctor in a government hospital and a superspecialist in a private hospital could be considered on a par while deciding the reimbursements.

It seems the CM realised it was not worth sticking his neck out for the contentious law in an election year. The whole episode, if anything, is a lesson for even seasoned politicians like Gehlot that blind populism, even if taken in "good faith" but cut off from ground realities, can backfire. ■

EPS

SKILLED SURVIVOR

By Amarnath K. Menon

Barely hours after the Madras High Court endorsed his election on March 30, Edappadi K. Palaniswami (EPS) was officially elevated to the all-powerful post of the general secretary (GS) of the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) party. Fawning supporters brought along a fur cap and dark glasses—the favourite fashion accessories of party founder M.G. Ramachandran (MGR)—for the former Tamil Nadu chief minister to try on, in an attempt to resurrect memories of the party's early days. MGR and his protégé J. Jayalalithaa had held the post till their respective deaths.

Jayalalithaa's ambitious consort V.K. Sasikala took over the reins in December 2016, but her conviction on corruption charges just three months later led to EPS becoming the "accidental CM". This after prostrating before Sasikala who had handpicked him to be proxy chief minister before she went to jail. EPS, along with another former CM, O. Panneerselvam (OPS), soon took control of the party.

OPS continues to be his main challenger. The former party coordinator will pursue the battle as long as he can, though he came up woefully short in the election for the post of general secretary by the party general council on July 11 last year. Of the 2,665 members, 2,460 had backed EPS. OPS challenged the result in the courts and has tried to put as many hurdles as possible to stall EPS. On April 3, though, a bench of the Madras High Court refused to grant OPS and other expelled AIADMK leaders any

BJP IN BIHAR

IN SEARCH OF NEW ALIGNMENTS

By Amitabh Srivastava

Just over a year to go before the general election, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) seems to have borrowed a leaf out of Chief Minister Nitish Kumar's book in anointing Samrat Choudhary, 54, its new state unit president. Samrat, who took over the office on March 27, comes from the Kushwaha caste, a group belonging to the Other Backward Classes (OBC) that is said to be the second largest after the Yadavs in Bihar's caste pyramid. More significantly, the Kushwahas (or Koeris) are the 'Kush' in Bihar's Luv-Kush bloc

AT THE HELM
Amit Shah with new Bihar BJP chief Samrat Choudhary in Nawada, Apr. 2

